

TJ Murphy

Painting light, people and shared experience



01 Sunrise on Rainier from Denny Blaine with Eagle Catching Fish, 2024

Watercolor pastel on Arches cold press paper

60 × 22 in (W × H)

The view from Denny Blaine drew me from ink sketches into watercolor. I wanted to capture the luminosity of the sky. I have returned to this mountain, and to painting, again and again.

SEATTLE, WASHINGTON

PORTFOLIO / 2026

A journey into painting



TJ Murphy / Seattle

My journey

I began painting in 2020, after years working in data science. A practice of observing light became a commitment to making art.

Since then, I have made approximately 500 paintings. Travel, friendship and mentorship have carried the work from Seattle to El Salvador and Cape Town, and from paper into gardens and festival spaces.

ARTIST STATEMENT

I paint to capture the luminosity of changing light and the character of the people and places around me. Watching Mount Rainier from Denny Blaine, or the morning sky from my balcony, becomes a form of meditation: a way of slowing down and noticing color before it changes.

With three primary colors and a dark tone, I build each painting through mixing and layering. Watercolor pastel gives me deep saturation, while the texture of the paper creates granulation. Shorelines, birds and the meeting of sea and sky return throughout the work. In portraiture, I look for the expression that makes a person distinctly themselves.

My outdoor murals extend this practice into acrylic, spray paint and airbrush. Whether a painting lives in a garden or grows through the participation of festivalgoers, I want it to become part of the life around it.

Changing light

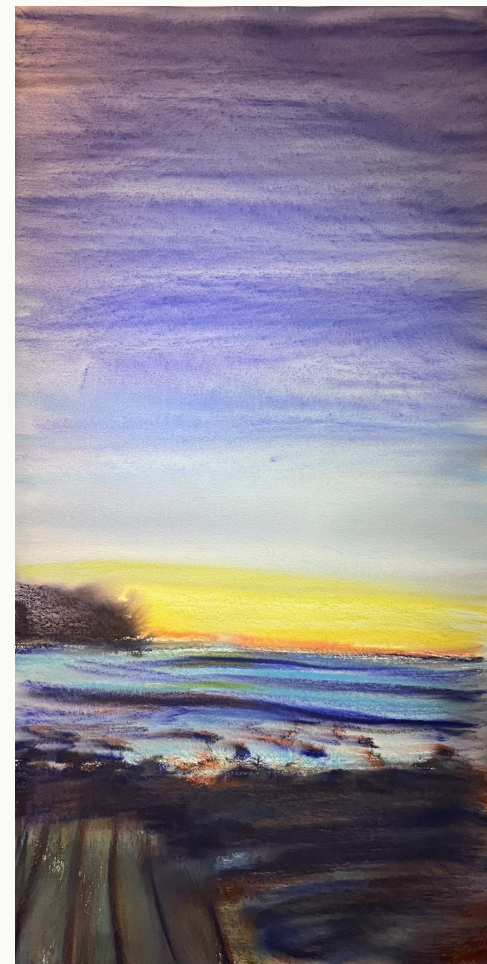


02 Sunset on Sucia Island in Puget Sound, 2024

Watercolor pastel on Arches cold press paper

24 × 15 in (W × H)

Water, distant shorelines and brief changes in the sky are recurring subjects. The paintings begin with looking: the warmth of a horizon, a band of reflected color, the shape of a cloud before it moves.

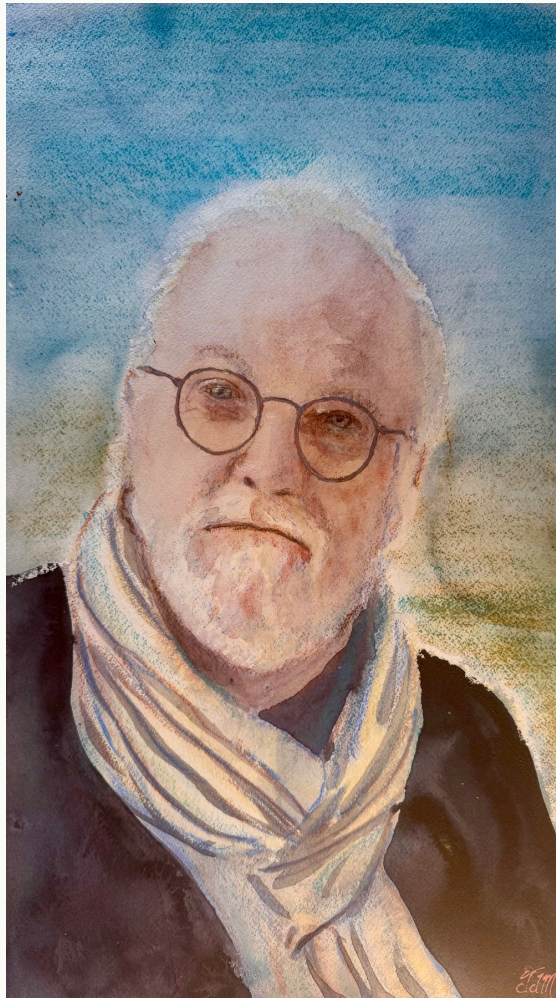


03 El Zonte at Sunrise, El Salvador, 2023

Watercolor pastel on Arches cold press paper

24 × 48 in (W × H)

People close to the work



04 Paul Murphy: my Dad, 2025

Watercolor pastel on Arches cold press paper
15 × 24 in (W × H)



05 Chase Toole, 2025

Watercolor pastel on Arches cold press paper

FRIENDSHIP & MENTORSHIP

Chase Toole

Chase and I were neighbors at the Nantucket in Seattle. A professional concept artist in the video game industry, he has been my art mentor for almost a decade.

He now lives in Montreal, but we still meet regularly to discuss my artistic development. His encouragement has pushed me to learn new skills and keep improving.

Imagined worlds

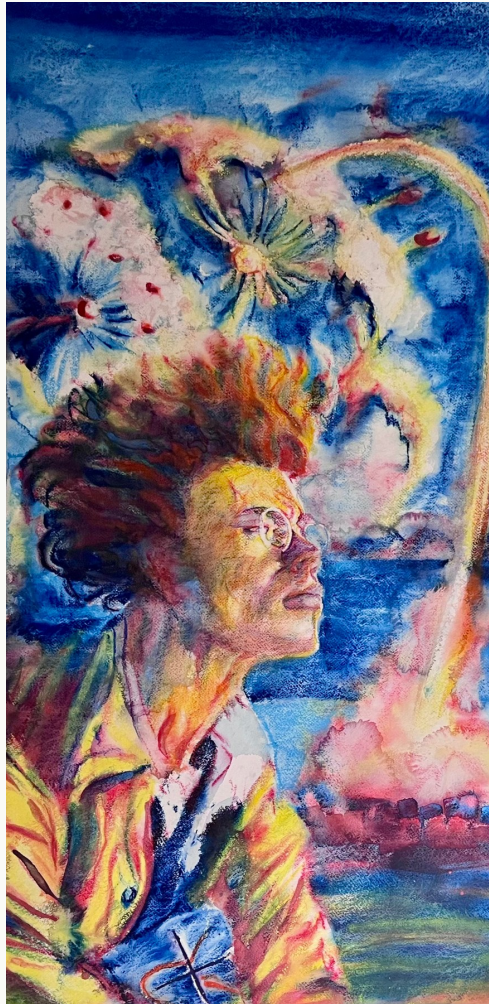
THE BOUNTY OF SATOSHI

Wonder and achievement

These paintings grew out of concept work for a project to monumentalize the origin story of Bitcoin.

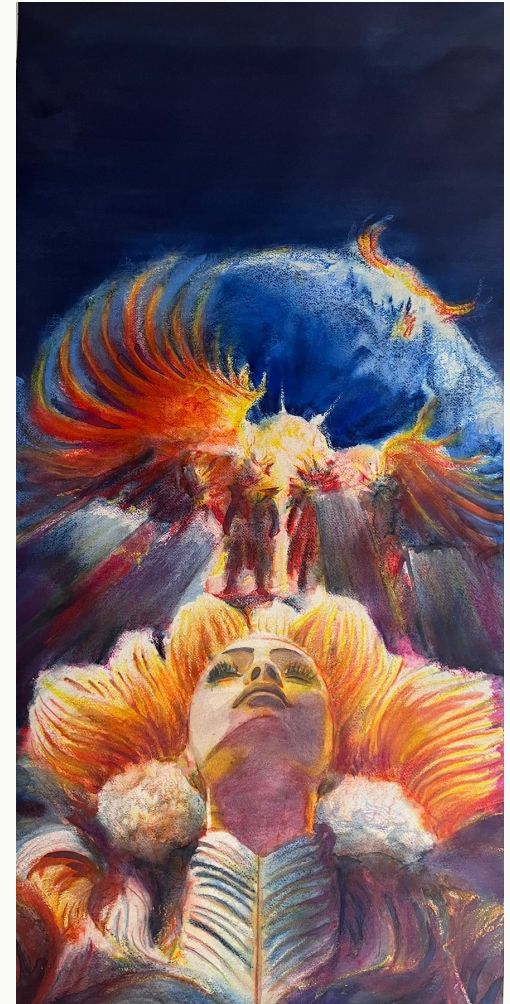
Wonder brings together awe at the beauty of nature and at technological achievement.

Achievement represents the birth of the network: a moment of creation after its challenges have been confronted.



06 Wonder, 2024

Watercolor pastel on Arches cold press paper
24 × 48 in (W × H)



07 Achievement, 2024

Watercolor pastel on Arches cold press paper
24 × 48 in (W × H)

Painting in shared spaces



08 Friends Club, 2026

Acrylic, spray paint and airbrush on a shipping container
40 x 9 ft (W x H) · Lillooet, British Columbia

A mountain valley, a waveform and a journey across the landscape became a 40-foot festival mural. Festivalgoers chose vinyl dancer silhouettes and placed them on the painting, adding themselves to its story.



09 Cormorant Presiding over Sunset on Puget Sound, 2026

Acrylic on board · Garden commission · Seattle

A favorite view from Golden Gardens becomes part of a private garden. The cormorant, sailboats and Olympic Mountains anchor the scene; colors from the planting and landscape carry the painting beyond the board.

[Explore the mural projects](#)

The art of going all in

A DOCUMENTARY BY GAVIN ROBERTSON

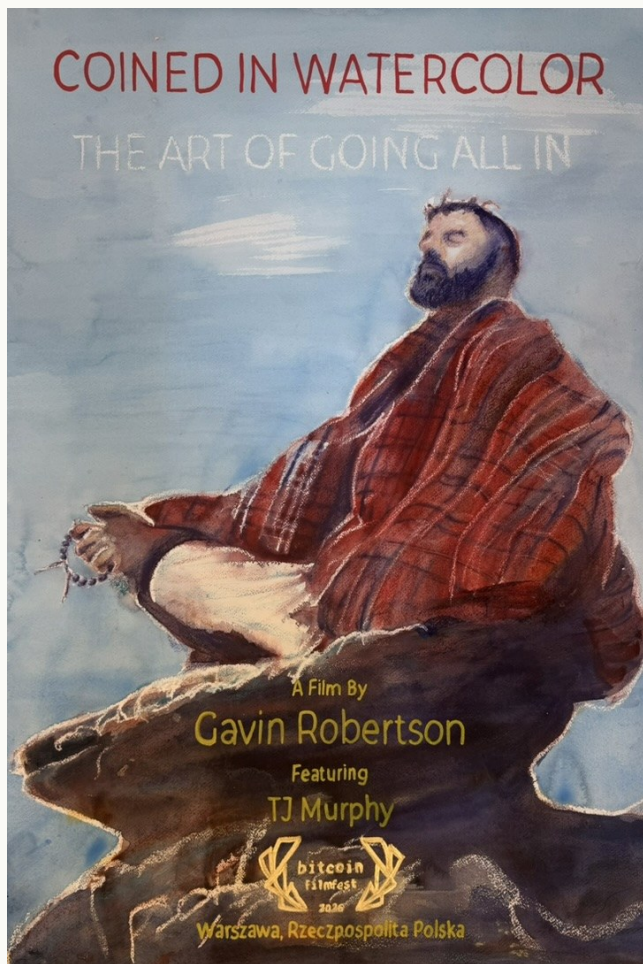
Coined in Watercolor: The Art of Going All In

Gavin and I were neighbors at the Nantucket in Seattle. Our conversations about Bitcoin, my art projects and the rock opera I was developing led him to propose a documentary about my journey into art.

We filmed in Seattle and in his hometown of Cape Town, traveling there together for a Bitcoin conference with my paintings. The documentary premiered at the Bitcoin Film Festival in Warsaw in 2026.

I painted the poster from a frame of myself meditating on Table Mountain, then gave the painting to the festival organizer.

[Watch the documentary](#)



10 Coined in Watercolor Film Poster, 2026

Watercolor pastel on Arches cold press paper
70 × 100 cm (W × H)

Continue the conversation

SELECTED EXHIBITIONS

Victrola Coffee Roasters

Seattle · 2026

Studio 601

Pioneer Square, Seattle · 2023

Additional exhibitions in El Salvador and Cape Town, South Africa.

[View the exhibition archive](#)

ART BOOKS

Watercolor Portraits

A collection of portraits in watercolor pastel.

Watercolor Landscapes

Changing skies, shorelines and reflected light.

Reflections on Time

Poems by Paul Michael Murphy, illustrated by TJ Murphy.

Commissions & collaborations

Portrait commissions, outdoor murals and collaborative art projects.

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VIEW THE PORTFOLIO ONLINE